

AUSTIN V. SMITH

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EMPLOYMENT

2025– Postdoctoral Researcher (Associate Data Scientist), School of Public Policy & Urban Affairs, Northeastern University.

EDUCATION

2025 Ph.D., Economics, University of Arizona
2021 M.A., Economics, University of Arizona
2020 B.A., Economics and Mathematics, *summa cum laude*, Lewis & Clark College

RESEARCH FIELDS

Labor Economics, Applied Microeconomics, Public Economics, Economics of Crime

JOB MARKET PAPER

The Boss in Blue: Supervisors and Police Behavior

Conditionally Accepted, American Economic Journal: Economic Policy

This paper studies the role of first-line police supervisors (sergeants) in the enforcement decisions of their officers. Leveraging rotations of officers between sergeants, I estimate causal effects of individual sergeants on arrests. Moving an officer from a 10th to 90th percentile sergeant increases monthly arrests by 42%. Sergeant effects on serious and low-level arrests are weakly correlated and operate through distinct behavioral mechanisms: sergeants who drive low-level arrests disproportionately increase discretionary drug enforcement, while those who increase serious arrests expand officers' 911 call volume. These findings position supervisors as critical actors in shaping police behavior and offer new insights for reform.

WORKING PAPERS

“Who You Gonna Call?” 911 Call Takers and Police Discretion

Police officers make high-stakes decisions under uncertainty, often acting on information from 911 call takers. Using quasi-random assignment of calls to call takers in Dallas, I show that variation in call takers' risk assessments significantly affects arrests. Calls upgraded to priority increase arrests by 53% relative to the mean, primarily for low-level offenses. These effects are partly driven by officers using call information to inform evaluations of suspect culpability, with stronger responses among inexperienced officers or in racially discordant neighborhoods. The results highlight the critical role of call takers and officer information processing in shaping enforcement.

The Effects of 911 Response Size

I estimate the effects of allocating more officers to 911 calls. In order to circumvent the endogenous assignment of more officers to calls with greater unobserved severity, I leverage exogenous variation in the amount of double-crewed patrol vehicles across shifts. I find that police are more likely to use their enforcement powers when additional officers are dispatched: an additional officer being dispatched to a call increases the likelihood of an arrest being made by 24% relative to the mean. I provide suggestive evidence that officers are more effective at incapacitating criminals when response sizes are

larger. My results highlight an understudied feature of patrol allocation that police departments ought to consider when making deployment decisions.

WORK IN PROGRESS

Detective Quality and Investigative Output (with Matthew B. Ross and Carly Will Sloan)

Clearance and Crime Prevention (with Catarina Meneses, Matthew B. Ross, and Carly Will Sloan)

Immigration Enforcement Partnerships and Local Police Activity (with Spencer Cooper)

GRANTS AND FELLOWSHIPS

2025	Arnold Ventures Criminal Justice Research Grant (\$121,800)
2024	Graduate Research Fellowship, National Institute of Justice (\$39,499)

AWARDS AND HONORS

2024	Graduate Student Award, Southern Economic Association
2023	Best Third-Year Paper, University of Arizona
2022	Steve Manos Prize for Best Second-Year Paper, University of Arizona
2020	Honors in Economics, Lewis & Clark College
2020	Phi Beta Kappa, Lewis & Clark College

PRESENTATIONS

2026	Colloquium on Personnel Economics, American Society of Evidence Based Policing Conference, San Diego State University [‡] , Wellesley College [‡]
2025	Virtual Crime Economics Seminar (ViCE), Providence College, Transatlantic Workshop on the Economics of Crime, Conference on Empirical Legal Studies, University of Connecticut
2024	Texas Economics of Crime Workshop, Workshop on the Economics of Crime for Junior Scholars, Southern Economic Association
2023	APPAM Fall Research Conference [†]

* coauthor presentation † discussant ‡ scheduled

WORKSHOPS ATTENDED

2023	Price Theory Summer Camp, Becker Friedman Institute, University of Chicago
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TEACHING

Instructor of Record, University of Arizona

2024	Economic Strategy for Business Decisions (online, asynchronous)
2022–2023	Economics of Sports

Teaching Assistant, University of Arizona

2024	Economics of Crime; Intermediate Microeconomics
2023	Economics of Strategy
2022	Econometrics; Economics of Sports
2021	Basic Economic Issues; Public Sector Economics; Microeconomic Analysis for Business Decisions
2020	Macroeconomic and Global Institutions and Policy; Global and Financial Economics and Strategy

PROFESSIONAL SERVICE

Referee Journal of Public Economics, Public Choice

TECHNICAL SKILLS

R, Stata, Julia, Causal Inference, High Performance Computing, $\LaTeX$

REFERENCES

Matthew B. Ross

Associate Professor
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Daniel Herbst

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John Drabicki (Teaching Reference)

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